



FULL-BLEED HERO PHOTOGRAPH
RECOMMENDED: BAY OF ISLANDS / CAPE REINGA

— YOUR JOURNEY BEGINS HERE

Northland Relocation Guide

WRITTEN BY ETHICARE RESOURCING · TE TAI TOKERAU



Kia ora, and a warm welcome to Aotearoa.

Kia ora, and a warm welcome to Te Tai Tokerau, the subtropical region at the very top of Aotearoa.

Northland is New Zealand's warmest, most relaxed region — two coastlines, ancient kauri forests and the birthplace of the nation at Waitangi. Whangārei is the only city, a friendly harbour hub where the pace is gentle and the beach is never far.

This guide covers everything from housing and transport to healthcare, finances and where to explore on your days off.



Lifestyle / welcome photograph

RECOMMENDED: WHANGĀREI WATERFRONT OR FAMILY

Nau mai, haere mai ki Aotearoa! (Welcome to New Zealand!)

Ngā mihi nui,
The Ethicare Team

What's inside

01	Welcome & Overview	History, culture, transport and climate	04
02	Healthcare	The health system, GPs, pharmacies, urgent care	09
03	Banking & Finance	Bank accounts, IRD, KiwiSaver, getting paid	11
04	Cost of Living	Prices, an example budget & Sophie's insights	13
05	Housing & Areas	Renting and a guide to the suburbs	16
06	Shopping & Food	Malls, supermarkets, world food, worship	20
07	Recreation & Travel	Things to do, plus weekend trips	24
08	Education & Family	Schooling, zoning, childcare & family life	28
09	Practical Info	Checklists, emergencies, community & phrases	32

QUICK FACTS

LOCATION

Northern tip of the North Island

CLIMATE

Subtropical – warm, humid

DRIVE TO AUCKLAND

~2.5 hours

MAIN CITY

Whangārei (~57,000)

MAIN HOSPITAL

Whangārei Hospital

NEARBY

Bay of Islands, Cape Reinga

The winterless north

Northland — Te Tai Tokerau — stretches from the upper Auckland boundary to Cape Reinga, where the Tasman Sea meets the Pacific. It is New Zealand's warmest and one of its most historically significant regions.

57K

WHANGĀREI RESIDENTS

190_{KM}

OF COASTLINE & BEACHES

2

COASTLINES — EAST & WEST

Why many professionals enjoy Northland

- A subtropical, winterless climate
- A relaxed, outdoors-first pace of life
- World-class beaches and diving on the doorstep
- New Zealand's founding history at Waitangi

Where Aotearoa began

Northland holds a special place in New Zealand's story — it was here, at Waitangi in 1840, that the Treaty of Waitangi was signed. The region has a strong Māori presence and a deep sense of history.

Te Tai Tokerau has one of the highest proportions of Māori residents in the country, and tikanga (custom) and te reo are woven through daily life.

The Waitangi Treaty Grounds, the giant kauri Tāne Mahuta in the Waipoua Forest, and the historic stone buildings of Kerikeri are all within easy reach.



Cultural moment

RECOMMENDED: WHANGĀREI LANDMARK

“

From the Treaty Grounds to Ninety Mile Beach, Northland holds the heart of the nation's story.

ON LIFE IN NORTHLAND

Getting around

Here is how people get around Northland day to day – and what to know about driving in New Zealand.

DRIVING

A car is essential – Northland is spread out, with State Highway 1 the main spine north from Auckland.

WHANGĀREI

The compact city centre, marina and Town Basin are walkable; local buses serve the suburbs.

AIR

Whangārei and Kerikeri have domestic airports with direct flights to Auckland in around 40 minutes.

FERRIES

Passenger ferries link Paihia and Russell in the Bay of Islands.

On the road

- New Zealanders drive on the left
- You can usually drive on a valid overseas licence for up to 12 months before converting to a NZ one
- A local transport card makes buses and trains easy
- Keep your overseas licence and any translation handy when you first arrive

A year in the local climate

Northland has New Zealand's mildest, most subtropical climate — warm humid summers, gentle winters and plenty of sunshine. Snow and frost are virtually unknown.

Summer

DEC – FEB

22–26°

AVG DAYTIME

Autumn

MAR – MAY

18–22°

AVG DAYTIME

Winter

JUN – AUG

12–16°

AVG DAYTIME

Spring

SEP – NOV

16–20°

AVG DAYTIME



Seasonal / scenic photograph

RECOMMENDED: BAY OF ISLANDS / TĀNE MAHUTA

The subtropical climate means swimming much of the year and gardens that flourish. Bring light layers and a raincoat — warm rain showers pass quickly.

Healthcare in Northland

Healthcare is delivered by Health New Zealand | Te Whatu Ora across the region, centred on Whangārei Hospital with smaller hospitals serving rural communities.

Whangārei Hospital

The region's main public hospital — acute, surgical, medical, maternity and emergency services for all of Northland.

Bay of Islands Hospital (Kawakawa)

A rural hospital providing medical, maternity and outpatient care for the mid-north.

Dargaville & Kaitia Hospitals

Smaller hospitals serving the Kaipara and Far North with local and emergency care.

Private & ACC

Private clinics operate in Whangārei; ACC provides no-fault accident cover for everyone.

Public & private

- Public healthcare is funded through general taxation
- ACC provides no-fault accident cover for everyone
- Private hospitals offer elective procedures and shorter waits
- Many residents hold private health insurance alongside the public system

GPs, pharmacies & urgent care

Registering with a GP and dentist

After you settle in, enrol with a local GP (General Practitioner). Enrolment means subsidised visits — typically around NZ\$50–\$70 when enrolled, more if you are a casual patient. Many practices allow online enrolment once you have an address. Dental care is private; expect roughly NZ\$90–\$150 for a check-up.

Pharmacies

Pharmacies are found throughout the region. Prescriptions are partly subsidised once you are enrolled with a GP — commonly a small standard charge per item.

Emergency & after-hours

- **Emergency Departments** — for urgent or critical care; in an emergency, dial 111
- **Urgent care clinics** — accident & medical clinics offer extended-hours care
- **Healthline 0800 611 116** — free 24/7 advice from registered nurses

Setting up your finances

Getting your finances in order early makes day-to-day life much easier. Most of this can be started before you arrive.

Opening a bank account

The major banks are ANZ, ASB, BNZ, Kiwibank and Westpac. You will usually need your passport, work or resident visa, and proof of a NZ address. Many banks let you start online before arrival, then activate in person. Ask for online banking and a debit card at the same time.

Tax (IRD number)

Every worker needs an IRD number from Inland Revenue. Apply online once you have a NZ address and bank account; processing usually takes around 7–10 working days. Give the number to your payroll team as soon as it arrives so the correct tax is applied. Wages are commonly paid fortnightly.

● Tip

Start your bank account application before you fly — having an account number ready makes your IRD application and payroll setup much smoother.

KiwiSaver & sending money home

KiwiSaver is a government-supported retirement savings scheme. On a work visa you can usually opt in or out. Contributions are a percentage of your pay (commonly 3%, 4%, 6%, 8% or 10%), with employers contributing at least 3%. You can withdraw your funds if you permanently leave New Zealand.

Sending money overseas: banks can transfer internationally, but specialist services such as Wise or OFX are often cheaper and faster. Always compare the exchange rate and the fees before moving larger amounts.

SET UP	WHY IT MATTERS	WHEN
Bank account	Receive salary, pay bills locally	Before / on arrival
IRD number	Be taxed correctly	First weeks
KiwiSaver	Retirement savings + employer top-up	When you start work
ACC	No-fault accident cover	Automatic

What life costs in Northland

Northland is among the more affordable regions, with housing well below the big cities — though rural living means budgeting for a car and travel.

\$520/wk

3-BED HOUSE (APPROX. MEDIAN)

\$2.80/L

APPROX. PETROL PRICE

Left

SIDE OF THE ROAD

EVERYDAY ITEM	APPROX. PRICE (NZ\$)
1 litre of milk	\$2.50 – \$3.50
Loaf of bread	\$2.50 – \$4.00
Dozen eggs	\$7 – \$10
Flat white coffee	\$5.50 – \$6.50
Mid-range meal for one	\$25 – \$40
Monthly gym membership	\$60 – \$100
Home broadband	\$75 – \$100 / month

Prices are indicative and change over time — use the calculators at the back of this guide for a personalised estimate.

An example monthly budget

A rough single-person monthly budget for a Northland renter. Yours will vary with lifestyle, household size and suburb.

CATEGORY	APPROX. MONTHLY (NZ\$)
Rent (room / small 1-bed)	\$1,200 – \$1,900
Power & water	\$160 – \$240
Internet	\$75 – \$100
Transport / fuel	\$200 – \$320
Groceries	\$450 – \$650
Mobile phone	\$30 – \$50
Entertainment	\$150 – \$300
Estimated total	\$2,300 – \$3,500

Make it personal

- Use Numbeo to compare Northland with your current city
- Map your own incomings and outgoings with the Sorted budget planner (sorted.org.nz)

A note from Sophie

A personal word from our Founder on what makes Northland special — and who it tends to suit.



● SOPHIE'S INSIGHTS

Northland is the place I send people who want the warmth — in both senses. The climate is the kindest in the country, and the communities are tight-knit and welcoming.

If you love the outdoors and a slower rhythm, you'll settle in fast. Just plan for a car, and let the beach become part of your routine.

Sophie Careem · Founder & Director, Ethicare Resourcing

● From the Ethicare team

Your Ethicare contact is here to help with every step of your move to Northland — from accommodation to payroll setup. Reach out any time.

Finding a place to live

Whangārei offers everything from harbourside apartments to suburban family homes, with coastal and rural options across the wider region.



Housing / suburb photograph

RECOMMENDED: SUBURBAN STREET OR APARTMENTS

Useful property websites

- trademe.co.nz/property – NZ's largest rental marketplace
- realestate.co.nz – nationwide rentals and homes for sale

A guide to the areas

An orientation to the main areas of Northland – each with its own character, price point and who it tends to suit.

Whangārei city & Town Basin

Walkable centre with the marina, cafés and the Hundertwasser Art Centre – handy for the hospital.

Tikipunga & Kamo

Established northern suburbs popular with families, with schools and shops.

Onerahi & the harbour

Coastal suburbs near the airport with sea views and an easy commute.

Kerikeri & the Bay of Islands

An hour north – subtropical, characterful and a magnet for those wanting coastal village life.

Across the wider region

Whangārei Heads & Parua Bay

Coastal peninsulas with beaches and bush, a scenic drive from the city.

Kerikeri & Paihia

Subtropical Bay of Islands towns — characterful, touristy and warm year-round.

Dargaville & the Kaipara

Affordable rural west-coast living near the giant kauri forests.

Kaitia & the Far North

Remote, affordable and close to Ninety Mile Beach and Cape Reinga.

A tip on choosing

- Think about your commute to work and school zones if you have children
- Where you live can decide which state school your children attend — check the zone before you sign
- Many people rent for a few months first to get to know the areas

Utilities, rates & rubbish

POWER & GAS

Choose from providers like Genesis, Mercury, Meridian and Contact. Compare rates on Powerswitch (powerswitch.org.nz).

WATER & RATES

Council rates fund local services; if you rent, rates are usually included in your rent.

RUBBISH & RECYCLING

Kerbside collection is run by the local council, with separate bins for rubbish, recycling and food scraps.

INTERNET

Most homes have fibre broadband; Spark, One NZ and 2degrees are the main providers.

Set-up quick links

Compare power

powerswitch.org.nz

Post & parcels

nzpost.co.nz

Tenancy advice

tenancy.govt.nz

Where to shop

Northland offers malls, town centres and weekend markets. A few of the main ones:

Whangārei (Okara & CBD)

The region's main shopping – Okara Park retail, the Town Basin and the central city.

Tikipunga & Kamo

Suburban shopping centres for everyday needs in the northern suburbs.

Kerikeri

Boutique shopping and the famous Saturday Old Packhouse Market.

Markets

Whangārei Growers' Market and Kerikeri's markets for fresh local produce.

Supermarkets & groceries

New Zealand's supermarkets fall into a few main groups. Knowing the difference helps you balance budget and convenience.

Pak'nSave

The cheapest of the big chains — a no-frills, bulk-buy warehouse format. Best for budget shopping.

Woolworths

Mid-range and widespread, with strong online shopping and delivery (formerly Countdown).

New World

More upmarket, with a wider fresh and specialty range.

Four Square & FreshChoice

Smaller neighbourhood stores for convenience and top-ups.

Whangārei has Pak'nSave, Woolworths and New World; smaller towns rely on New World, Four Square and local stores. Bring your own bags — single-use plastic bags are banned.

Specialty & international food

One of the joys of settling into Northland is finding the flavours of home — or exploring new ones.

Halal & South Asian

A smaller but growing selection in Whangārei; many supermarket meat lines are halal-certified — check the label.

Asian groceries

Asian supermarkets and takeaways in central Whangārei serve the local community.

Markets & local

Northland's real strength is its fresh local produce, seafood and farmers' markets.

Smaller independent stores open and close over time — a quick search for "halal butcher near me" or your home cuisine will surface the current options near your suburb.

Places of worship

Northland reflects New Zealand's spiritual diversity, with welcoming communities across many faiths.

Whangārei has Christian churches of many denominations, a mosque, and Hindu and Buddhist communities, with more in the Bay of Islands.

Finding your community

- Most faith communities list service times and locations online
- Many warmly welcome newcomers and visitors
- They can be one of the quickest ways to build a support network when you arrive

A world of lifestyle on your doorstep

Northland is built for the outdoors — diving, surfing, fishing and forest walks, with the country's finest beaches a short drive away.



Recreation hero photograph

RECOMMENDED: BAY OF ISLANDS / TĀNE MAHUTA

Don't-miss experiences

- Cruise the Bay of Islands and watch for dolphins
- Stand before Tāne Mahuta, the giant kauri
- Walk the Waitangi Treaty Grounds
- Swim and dive at the Poor Knights Islands

Ten things not to miss

A starter list to get to know Northland and the wider region.

- 1 Bay of Islands cruise**
Dolphins, island stops and the famous Hole in the Rock.
- 2 Tāne Mahuta**
Stand before the giant kauri in Waipoua Forest.
- 3 Waitangi Treaty Grounds**
Where the nation's founding document was signed in 1840.
- 4 Poor Knights Islands**
World-class diving in a marine reserve.
- 5 Ninety Mile Beach**
Drive the vast sweep of sand to Cape Reinga.
- 6 Cape Reinga**
Watch two oceans meet at the top of the country.
- 7 Whangārei Falls**
A pretty waterfall and walk on the city's edge.
- 8 Hokianga Harbour**
Giant sand dunes and a tranquil west-coast harbour.
- 9 Tutukaka Coast**
Beaches, snorkelling and the gateway to the Poor Knights.
- 10 Hundertwasser Art Centre**
Whangārei's striking architectural landmark.

Travel from Whangārei

Northland is a great base for exploring. Some favourite weekend escapes:

Bay of Islands (~1 hr)

Island cruises, history and subtropical beaches.

Hokianga & Waipoua (~1.5 hrs)

Kauri forests and the peaceful Hokianga.

Cape Reinga & the Far North (~3 hrs)

Ninety Mile Beach and the meeting of the seas.

Auckland (~2.5 hrs)

The big city for events, shopping and the airport.

Flying onward

- Domestic flights reach the main centres in around 1–2 hours
- Book early for the best fares on Air New Zealand and Jetstar
- Many regions are also linked by scenic road and rail journeys

Schooling & study

Northland offers a full range of early childhood education, schools and tertiary study.

Early Childhood Education (ECE)

Kindergartens, daycare, Montessori, kōhanga reo and home-based care for ages 0–5. Government 20-hours funding applies for ages 3–5.

Primary & intermediate

State, state-integrated and private schools for Years 1–8.

Secondary

Years 9–13, working towards NCEA, the national qualification.

Tertiary

Universities and institutes of technology across the country.

School terms run late January to mid-December, in four terms with two-week breaks in April, July and October.

School zones come first

In New Zealand, where you live usually determines which state school your children can attend. For many families, the school decision leads the choice of where to rent or buy.

In-zone = guaranteed

Children living inside a school's enrolment zone are guaranteed a place at that school.

Out-of-zone = ballot

If you live outside the zone you can still apply, but places aren't guaranteed – popular schools run a ballot for limited spots.

Zones are street-by-street

Boundaries can run down the middle of a street, so check the exact address.

● **The order that works best**

1) Shortlist schools you like → 2) Check each school's zone map → 3) Search for rentals inside that zone → 4) Confirm the address is in-zone before you sign.

Childcare for working families

Early childhood (0–5). Daycare, kindergartens, Montessori and home-based care are widely available. The government's 20 Hours ECE funding subsidises care for ages 3–5 at participating centres.

Before & after school (OSCAR). Many schools and providers run breakfast clubs, after-school care and holiday programmes. Subsidies may be available through Work and Income for eligible families.

TYPE OF CARE	APPROX. COST (NZ\$)
Full-time daycare (under 3)	\$350 – \$450 / week before subsidies
20 Hours ECE (ages 3–5)	Up to 20 hrs/week subsidised; extra hours charged
After-school care (OSCAR)	\$5 – \$15 per afternoon, varies by provider
School holiday programme	\$40 – \$60 per day, activity-based

Costs are indicative and vary by provider and suburb. If you'll work shifts, ask providers about flexible hours.

Northland for families

Beyond school and work, Northland is an easy, outdoorsy place to raise a family.

FREE & OUTDOORS

Beaches, the Town Basin loop and Whangārei Falls — much of the best family fun is free.

RAINY-DAY OPTIONS

The Hundertwasser Art Centre, Kiwi North and Claphams Clocks museum.

LIBRARIES & PLUNKET

Free local libraries run children's programmes; Plunket supports young families.

GETTING AROUND

A relaxed, car-friendly region — short drives to beaches and parks.

Settling kids in

- Children often settle fastest through school, sport and weekend activities
- Local clubs — football, netball, rugby, swimming — are inexpensive and welcoming
- They're a great way for the whole family to meet people

Pre-departure checklist

Work through these before you fly. Keep digital and printed copies of everything important.

Documents

- ☐ Passport + valid NZ visa (printed too)
- ☐ Job offer & employment contract
- ☐ Qualifications & certificates
- ☐ References & employment history

Money & travel

- ☐ Apply online for a NZ bank account
- ☐ Documents ready for your IRD number
- ☐ Confirm airline baggage allowance
- ☐ Book temporary accommodation

Your first weeks

- | | |
|---|--|
| ☐ Move into your accommodation | ☐ Open / activate your bank account |
| ☐ Apply for your IRD number | ☐ Get a NZ SIM card |
| ☐ Register with a local GP | ☐ Set up power, water and internet |
| ☐ Learn your transport routes to work | ☐ Save 111 and Healthline in your phone |
| ☐ Find your nearest pharmacy & supermarket | ☐ Explore your local neighbourhood |

● You're not alone

Your Ethicare contact is here to help with any of these steps – from accommodation to payroll setup. Reach out any time.

Key numbers & contacts

In any emergency – police, fire or ambulance – dial **111**.

Emergency & health

Emergency	111
Healthline	0800 611 116
Mental health	Call/text 1737
Police (non-urgent)	105

Everyday services

Tax (IRD)	ird.govt.nz
Immigration	immigration.govt.nz
AA roadside	0800 500 222
Local council	govt.nz/organisations

Banks

ANZ	anz.co.nz
ASB	asb.co.nz
BNZ	bnz.co.nz
Kiwibank	kiwibank.co.nz
Westpac	westpac.co.nz

Community & expat groups

One of the quickest ways to settle in is to find your people. Northland has active communities for almost every interest and background.

Facebook groups

Search for groups like "Expats in Northland", your home-country community, and local suburb buy/sell and parents' groups.

Meetup & interest groups

Meetup.com lists hiking, sport, hobby and newcomer groups — a relaxed way to meet people.

Sports & cultural clubs

Local football, netball, rugby and cricket clubs, plus cultural and faith communities, all welcome newcomers.

Workplace networks

Many hospitals and employers have social clubs and buddy systems for new and international staff.

Rainbow / LGBTQ+ community

- New Zealand is welcoming and progressive — marriage equality has been law since 2013
- There are strong legal protections against discrimination
- OutLine Aotearoa offers rainbow mental-health support (0800 688 5463)

Everyday Māori & Kiwi phrases

Te reo Māori is part of everyday life, and Kiwis have their own slang too.

Te reo Māori

Kia ora Hello / thanks

Nau mai, haere mai Welcome

Whānau Family

Hauora Health & wellbeing

Manaakitanga Hospitality, kindness

Mōrena Good morning

Ka kite anō See you later

Tamariki Children

Ngā mihi nui Many thanks

Aotearoa New Zealand

Kiwi slang

Sweet as Great / no worries

Keen Up for it

Dairy Corner shop

Jandals Flip-flops

Flatting Shared renting

Chur Cheers / thanks

Heaps Lots

Togs Swimwear

Shout Your turn to pay

Knackered Tired

Work out your cost of living.

Use these tools to estimate what life in Northland would really cost for you and your family.

Cost-of-living calculators

Compare cities (Numbeo)	numbeo.com/cost-of-living
Budget planner (Sorted)	sorted.org.nz/tools/budget-planner
Living-costs data (Stats NZ)	stats.govt.nz
Take-home pay (IRD)	ird.govt.nz

We hope you've found this guide useful. Moving to the other side of the world is a big step, and there's a lot to take in – so please don't feel you have to have it all figured out at once.

Whatever stage you're at, we're always happy to talk anything through – the big decisions or the small worries. Just reach out to your Ethicare contact whenever you need us.

Ngā mihi nui

The Ethicare team



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